to visit, to work, to invest, and to study, in modular cities laid out in American-style grids. Expatriates are highly visible in at least half a dozen Chinese cities. Soft power (and economic power) brings foreigners into China, and their presence in turn reinforces Chinese soft power. That is the not the case for India. Indians may or may not want to have global cities; but China's global cities are a growing source of soft power.

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Even China's secondary cities are impressively modern. In 2017, I suddenly decided to fly to the ancient city of Xi'an to see its famous terracotta warriors from the third century BCE. Not having done my homework on the city (or indeed on the excavation of the terracotta figures), I was left to do it on the airplane journey. In my ignorance, I had imagined a quaint tourist town, something along the lines of Siem Reap in Cambodia which has become the tourist hub for Angkor Wat – I pictured wandering out to the site and then strolling back for beer and local food. My hastily printed Google documents on Xi'an shook me out of my reverie. The city had once been one of China's great capital cities and was now home to over 12 million residents.

As I drove to my hotel some hours later, it struck me that no Indian city could match this second-tier Chinese city – not Mumbai, Bengaluru, or Hyderabad. In the days that followed, I saw not just the excavated terracotta warriors which are outside the city proper, but also attractions within the inner city. Downtown Xi'an had broad, clean streets, a convenient and user-friendly public transport system (especially the suburban trains), heavy but disciplined motorized traffic, well-dressed and healthy-looking people, and everywhere the facilities and resources one would encounter in a modern metropolitan environment.

At the terracotta excavations, the huge crowds were systematically channelled through the site in a way I had never experienced in India. Perhaps even more impressive was our guide. He was a dignified forty-year-old man dressed in a neat guide's uniform, spoke excellent English,